Porchlight Elder Companions

Friendly visits and rides for older neighbors living alone

STATUS	501(c)(3) public charity, Connecticut
FOUNDED	2014
BASED IN	East Rock, New Haven (works out of a volunteer's home office)
SERVES	Adults 70+ living alone in East Rock, Fair Haven Heights, and East Haven
ANNUAL BUDGET	About $42,000
STAFF	None paid; a volunteer coordinator receives a small stipend
VOLUNTEERS	About 55 matched visitors and drivers
REACH	About 80 older adults; roughly 2,500 visits and rides a year

MISSION

Porchlight keeps older neighbors connected, so no one ages alone behind a closed door.

OUR STORY

After her neighbor fell and lay alone for a day before anyone noticed, a retired nurse organized a weekly check-in among friends on her street. It grew into a matched visiting program, then added volunteer drivers for medical appointments and groceries.

WHO WE SERVE

Older adults, mostly women in their 80s, who live alone and have little family nearby. Many no longer drive. Some have early memory loss. Referrals come from churches, doctors' offices, and neighbors.

PROGRAMS

Weekly Companions
Each older adult is matched with a volunteer who visits once a week for an hour: conversation, cards, walks, or help with mail.

Porchlight Rides
Volunteer drivers provide rides to medical appointments, the pharmacy, and the grocery store.

Call Tree
Volunteers make short check-in calls on days between visits, and during storms and heat waves.

HOW WE'RE FUNDED

Individual donors and an annual pie sale (60%), a small grant from a local aging services fund (30%), and congregational gifts (10%).

WHAT WE TRACK TODAY

A paper log of visits and rides that the coordinator tallies each quarter. A volunteer roster. Nothing about loneliness, wellbeing, or health.

WHAT WE'RE WRESTLING WITH

A grant officer suggested a loneliness scale, but the coordinator doesn't want to 'test' the people she serves. The group is entirely volunteer-run, so any data collection must be very light.

A MOMENT FROM OUR WORK

A 91-year-old former schoolteacher and her companion, a graduate student from Ghana, have met every Wednesday for three years. She calls him 'my professor' and has corrected every one of his papers. (Details changed to protect privacy.)